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Governing Equitable Artificial Intelligence: A Comparative Study of Global North and South Perceptions in Education.

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Abstract

Artificial Intelligence (AI) has become a central emerging technology in education, offering new opportunities for personalised learning, automation, and data-driven decision-making. However, its adoption remains uneven across global regions, raising concerns about whether AI will reduce or reinforce existing educational inequalities. This study examines global perceptions of AI in education, with a particular focus on barriers, opportunities, and ethical issues relevant to the Global South. While existing scholarship highlights the transformative potential of AI, it also identifies significant risks relating to bias, transparency, inequality, and limited governance capacity. A key gap in the literature concerns the limited empirical evidence capturing end-user perspectives, particularly within under-resourced educational environments.

To address this, a quantitative online questionnaire was used to investigate awareness, perceived benefits, risks, ethical considerations, and governance expectations among respondents from the Global North and Global South. Descriptive analysis revealed moderate optimism regarding AI's ability to support equitable learning, contrasted with far stronger concerns about privacy, bias, and algorithmic risk. Over half of participants reported inadequate access to ethical AI guidance, indicating a notable ethical literacy gap. Respondents attributed primary responsibility for ensuring ethical AI use to governments and educational institutions, and identified data privacy, bias and fairness, and transparency as the most pressing ethical priorities.

These findings reinforce existing scholarship while offering new insight into how stakeholders perceive AI's benefits and risks as interconnected. The study concludes that equitable AI adoption requires investment in digital infrastructure, context-sensitive ethical frameworks, and inclusive governance models tailored to the needs of the Global South. Future research should explore qualitative perspectives and longitudinal trends to further assess AI readiness across diverse contexts.

Keywords: Artificial Intelligence, Education, Global South, Emerging Technologies, Equity.

1 Introduction

Artificial Intelligence (AI) and other emerging digital technologies have become central to contemporary debates on the future of education, offering new possibilities for personalised learning, intelligent tutoring, automated assessment, and data-driven decision-making. Over the past two decades, these technologies have begun to reshape educational systems worldwide; however, their integration remains uneven across regions (Varsik and Vosberg, 2024). While the Global North is increasingly embedding AI into digital learning ecosystems, adoption within the Global South is constrained by long-standing disparities in infrastructure, governance capacity, and teacher training (Miao and Holmes, 2023; Hawkins et al., 2021). These inequalities raise critical questions about whether AI will reduce educational disparities or deepen them.

International bodies such as UNESCO (Miao and Holmes, 2023) and the World Bank (Hawkins et al., 2021) emphasis that equitable AI deployment requires ethical safeguards, capacity building, and inclusive governance. Many Global South nations continue to face systemic challenges including limited broadband, insufficient digital devices, and fragmented policy environments. Without targeted intervention, AI-enabled education risks reinforcing existing inequalities across gender, socio-economic background, and geography.

Despite extensive research on AI in education, much of the literature focuses on technological solutions or global policy frameworks, with far less empirical attention given to the experiences of teachers and learners in under-resourced regions. Zawacki-Richter *et al.* (2019), explicitly finds that AI-in-education is technology-centred, dominated by the Global North, and the lack of end-user empirical evidence has created a disconnect between high-level narratives of AI-driven

educational transformation and the practical realities of implementation on the ground a gap this study seeks to address.

Motivated by such need, the aim of this study is to investigate how stakeholders across global regions perceive *emerging AI innovations* in education, with emphasis on identifying barriers, opportunities, and ethical concerns relevant to the Global South. Through quantitative survey data, the study examines awareness, perceived risks, expected benefits, and governance expectations associated with these emerging technologies. The research aims to inform equitable AI deployment by foregrounding user-level insights, contextual considerations, and the responsible integration of emerging educational innovations.

2 Literature Review

AI in Education: Global North and Global South Context

Emerging technologies such as AI are reshaping educational systems worldwide, with research showing that demographic and contextual factors significantly influence AI adoption. Teo (2019) identifies age and gender as key determinants of technology acceptance, even in technologically advanced regions. Structural inequalities particularly between the Global North and Global South impact digital readiness and institutional capacity, as highlighted by Pedro *et al*., (2019); and Holmes *et al*., (2019). Additionally, AI awareness and exposure are shaped by media discourse and academic communication, influencing perceptions of trust and capability (Zawacki-Richter *et al.,* 2019).

Theoretical and Policy Frameworks

Global frameworks provide the conceptual basis for responsible AI deployment. UNESCO's guidance emphasises inclusive, context-aware adoption (Miao and Holmes; 2023), while OECD principles call for fairness, transparency, and human oversight (OECD, 2021). The EU AI Act 2024 formalises a risk-based governance structure (European Commission, 2023). Scholars highlight AI's transformative potential for personalised learning (Luckin *et al.,* 2016) but also warn that insufficient regulation may exacerbate inequalities (Holmes *et al*., 2019; Baker & Smith, 2019). Ethical principles such as transparency, accountability, and fairness are widely regarded as essential (Jobin *et al.*, 2019; Floridi & Cowls, 2019; Long & Magerko, 2020).

Critical Synthesis of Evidence

The literature reveals a tension between AI's potential benefits and the risk of reinforcing inequality. AI may enhance personalisation and access, yet benefits remain unevenly distributed. Scholars frame AI in education as a socio-political project requiring ethical stewardship (Schiff *et al*., 2021, Selwyn, 2019). A major gap persists, empirical evidence capturing the lived experiences of educators and learners especially in Global South contexts remains limited. This gap motivates the present study.

3 Gap Analysis

Existing literature provides insight into technological, pedagogical, and ethical dimensions of AI, yet significant gaps remain, particularly for the Global South. First, much research relies on models tested in high-income contexts, limiting generalisability (Teo, 2019, Pedro *et al*., 2019). However, the inclusion of more recent systematic reviews enables temporal comparison with earlier Global North-centric studies, evidencing a measurable shift towards increased Global South representation rather than relying on authorial interpretation (Mustafa, 2024). Second, although awareness and exposure influence readiness (Zawacki-Richter *et al*., 2019), few studies offer comparative empirical analysis grounded in end-user perspectives across global regions. Third, frameworks such as UNESCO, OECD, and the EU AI Act (Miao and Holmes, 2023; OECD, 2021; European Commission, 2023) assume infrastructure levels do not present in many Global South contexts. Fourth, voices of end-users remain underrepresented, reinforcing the need for empirical studies. Addressing these gaps is essential for inclusive AI integration. To summarise, collectively, these gaps highlight a critical disconnect between global AI policy narratives, technological promises, and the practical realities of educational systems in the Global South. They reveal that existing research underrepresents user perspectives, over-relies on Global North contexts, and insufficiently addresses infrastructural and governance challenges. Addressing these gaps is essential for developing equitable, context-sensitive AI strategies providing the rationale and urgency for the primary research conducted in this study.

4 Methodology

Research Design and Data Collection

A quantitative online survey was employed to investigate perceptions of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in education across global regions. A questionnaire-based design was selected due to its suitability for capturing standardised attitudinal data from geographically dispersed respondents, enabling comparative analysis between the Global North and Global South while maintaining reliability and consistency (Bryman, 2016; Creswell and Creswell, 2018). This approach is well established within AI-in-education research, where surveys are frequently used to examine perceptions of

benefits, ethical risks, and institutional readiness (Zawacki-Richter *et al*., 2019; Sharma and Ha, 2025).

The questionnaire was designed using both Likert-scale and categorical items to capture awareness, attitudes, perceived risks, ethical concerns, and governance expectations. Likert-scale questions were chosen to assess subjective perceptions such as AI's potential to reduce educational inequality, concerns around data privacy and algorithmic bias, and the adequacy of ethical guidance. Likert scales are widely recognised as effective for measuring attitudes towards emerging technologies due to their clarity, reliability, and suitability for quantitative comparison (Likert, 1932; Boone and Boone, 2012). Categorical and multiple-choice questions were used to capture views on ethical responsibility and priority issues, reflecting the multi-stakeholder nature of AI governance emphasised in the literature (Floridi and Cowls, 2019; Nguyen et al., 2023).

The content of each questionnaire item was directly informed by themes identified in the literature review, including ethical risk, governance capacity, institutional readiness, and equity in AI deployment (Pedro *et al*., 2019; Miao and Holmes (2023). The inclusion of a Global North and Global South classification reflects empirical evidence that regional context significantly influences AI adoption and perception (Teo, 2019; Sharma and Ha, 2025). Participation was voluntary, responses were anonymous, and ethical guidelines on consent and data protection were followed.

Population and Sampling Strategy

The target population comprised adults (aged eighteen and over) engaged in higher education or related educational and computing contexts, including students, educators, and professionals. These stakeholders were selected because they are directly affected by the adoption of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in education and are therefore well positioned to assess its perceived benefits, ethical risks, and governance implications (Holmes *et al*., 2019; Zawacki-Richter *et al*., 2019).

A non-probability voluntary response sampling strategy was employed. This approach is commonly used in exploratory research on emerging technologies, particularly where geographically diverse participation is required (Bryman, 2016; Creswell and Creswell, 2018). The method enabled the inclusion of respondents from both the Global North and Global South, supporting the study's comparative focus on regional differences in AI perception and readiness.

Respondents self-identified their educational background region, allowing for meaningful comparison without collecting sensitive personal data. This aligns with ethical research principles and data minimisation requirements, while remaining analytically justified given evidence that regional context influences AI adoption and attitudes (Teo, 2019; Sharma and Ha, 2025). Although voluntary sampling limits statistical generalisability, it is considered appropriate for perception-based research in rapidly evolving domains such as AI. The study therefore provides exploratory insight rather than definitive population-level claims (Capraro et al., 2024).

Data Analysis Approach

Descriptive statistics summarised trends and regional differences. Frequency distributions and percentages were calculated, with cross-tabulation used to compare Global North vs South responses. Limited open-text responses were categorised thematically to capture contextual nuances.

Region was self-identified (Q5), with a "Prefer not to say" option included in line with the study's data-minimisation approach. Respondents selecting this option were retained in all whole-sample analyses (n = 39) but excluded from Global North versus Global South comparisons (n = 36). Percentages are calculated against the stated denominator and reported with raw frequencies. Q14 and Q15 permitted multiple selections ("choose one or more"); their percentages therefore represent the proportion of respondents selecting each option and may sum to more than 100%. Likert items used a five-point scale from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree).

Limitations

The study's findings are subject to methodological limitations, primarily due to the use of a voluntary response sample, which restricts the climate of opinion of the non-random dataset. The cross-sectional design prevents the establishment of longitudinal trends. Moreover, the reliance on single-item, self-reported perceptions limits construct validity. Consequently, the paper offers an exploratory, thematic snapshot of attitudes, which must be validated by larger, more representative, and longitudinal research

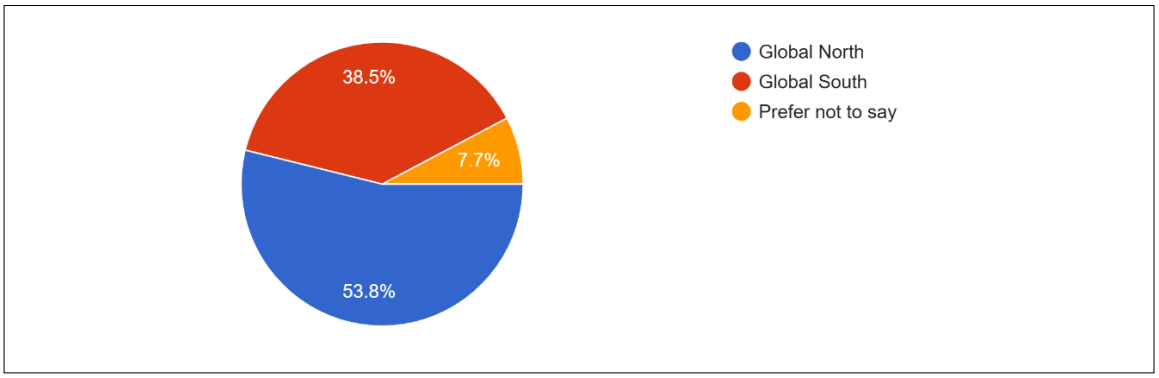
5 Findings and Discussion

Cross-Regional Representation and Converging Ethical Attitudes

Of the 39 respondents shown in Figure 1, 21 (53.8%) identified with the Global North, 15 (38.5%) identified with the Global South, and 3 (7.7%) selected the "Prefer not to say" category. These three respondents were retained in whole-sample results (n = 39), but comparative regional analyses were conducted using only the 36 respondents who could be classified into either Global North or Global South categories. To im-

prove transparency, all percentages reported throughout the findings section are accompanied by raw frequencies and denominators.

Figure 1: Q5. Which region best represents your educational background?

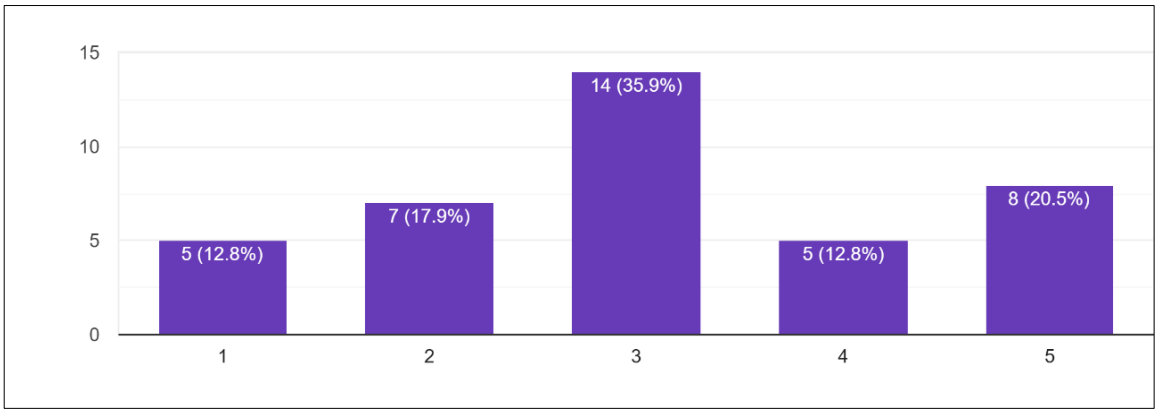


Despite these disparities, both groups expressed remarkably similar ethical concerns regarding the use of AI as an *emerging technology* used in education. This convergence supports the argument by Sharma and Ha (2025), that global AI ethics discourse is increasingly harmonised through shared digital media, transnational policy frameworks, and widespread public debates. The results suggest that ethical awareness surrounding AI has become internationally synchronised rather than regionally isolated.

Perceptions of AI's Role in Reducing Inequality

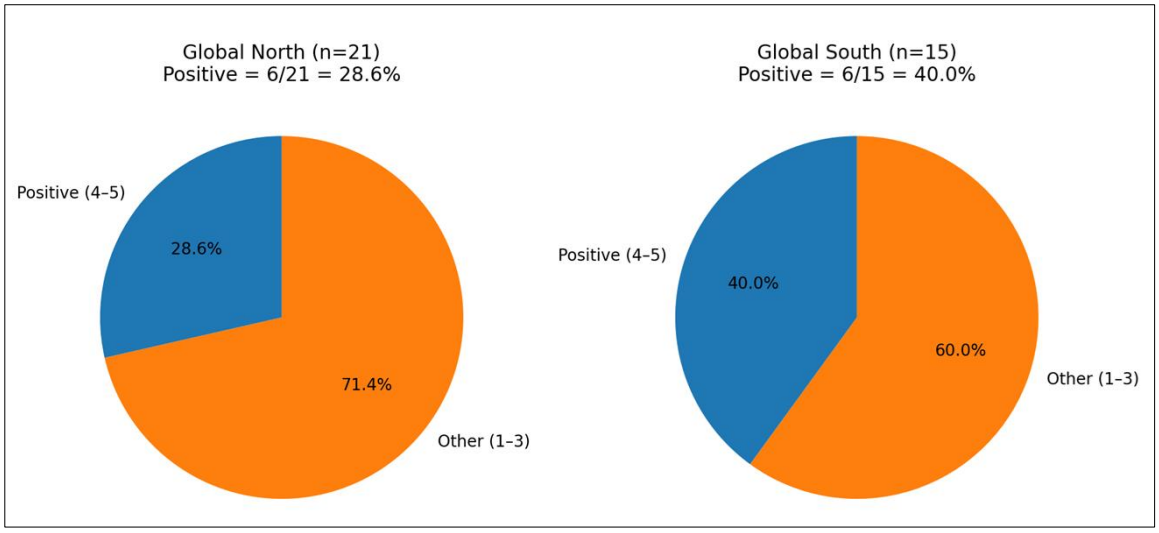
In Figure 2 (below), Responses to whether AI could help reduce educational inequality revealed mixed attitudes: 14 of 39 respondents (35.9%) selected the midpoint ("3"), while 13 of 39 (33.3%) chose "4" (n = 5) or "5" (n = 8), indicating moderate optimism.

Figure 2: Q10. AI could help reduce inequality between regions?



Interestingly in Figure 3 below, positive responses from the Global South (6 of 15; 40.0%) displayed an 11.4 percentage-point difference with the Global North (6 of 21; 28.6%) (see Appendix A).

Figure 3: Positivity towards AI reducing educational inequality

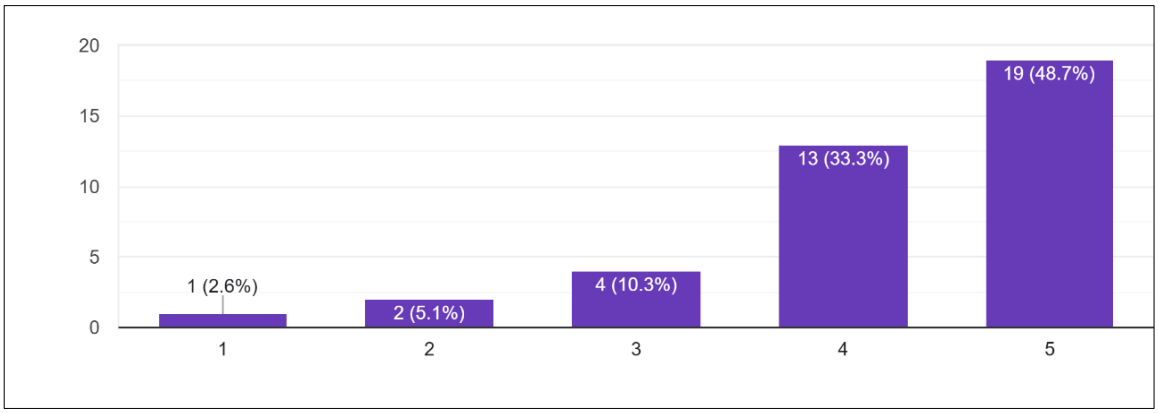


This pattern aligns with Capraro et al. (2024), who argue that perceptions of AI's developmental potential tend to be higher in emerging economies. However, the overall distribution also reflects persistent caution, suggesting uncertainty about whether existing conditions such as digital infrastructure and teacher training are sufficient to support equitable AI use .This interpretation is grounded in the secondary literature and gap analysis, which defines educational inequality in AI contexts primarily as disparities in infrastructure, institutional capacity, and teacher readiness rather than differences in ethical awareness alone (Miao et al., 2021; OECD, 2021; Zawacki-Richter *et al*., 2019).

Ethical Risks: Privacy, Bias, and Fairness

Concerns about ethical risks shown in Figure 4 (following page), were pronounced: 32 of 39 respondents (82.1%) rated privacy and algorithmic bias concerns as either "4" (n = 13) or "5" (n = 19).

Figure 4: Q11. AI may increase risks to data privacy and/or bias in education?

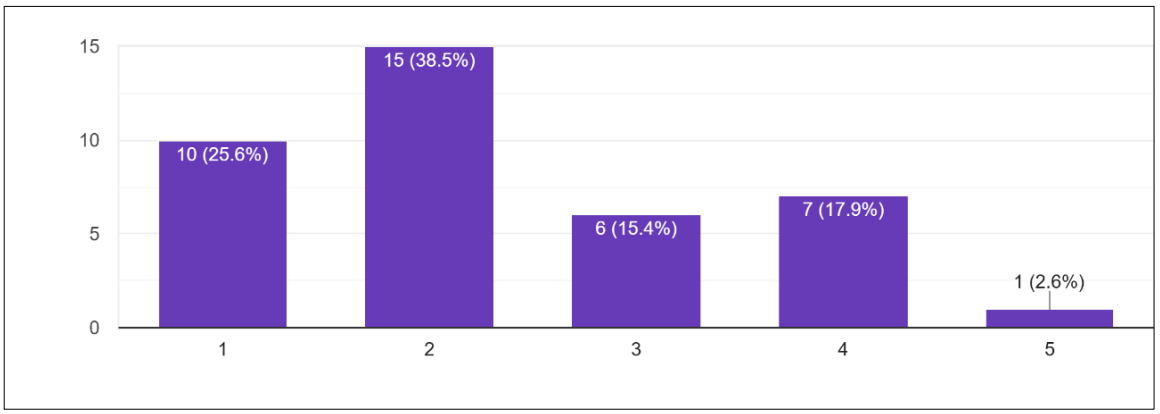


This finding echoes Ismail and Aloshi (2024), who identify privacy and fairness as the most widely recognised risks in AI-enhanced educational systems. The near-universal agreement across regions suggests that a shared global ethical literacy is emerging, with growing recognition of algorithmic harms independent of national context.

Institutional Readiness and Lack of Ethical Guidance

Participants expressed low confidence in Figure 5 below, in institutional preparedness for ethical AI adoption: 25 of 39 respondents (64.1%) selected "1" (n = 10) or "2" (n = 15) when asked about the adequacy of ethical guidance for AI in education, while only one respondent (2.6%) selected "5".

Figure 5: Q12. Teachers/Lecturers and students receive enough guidance on ethical use of AI?

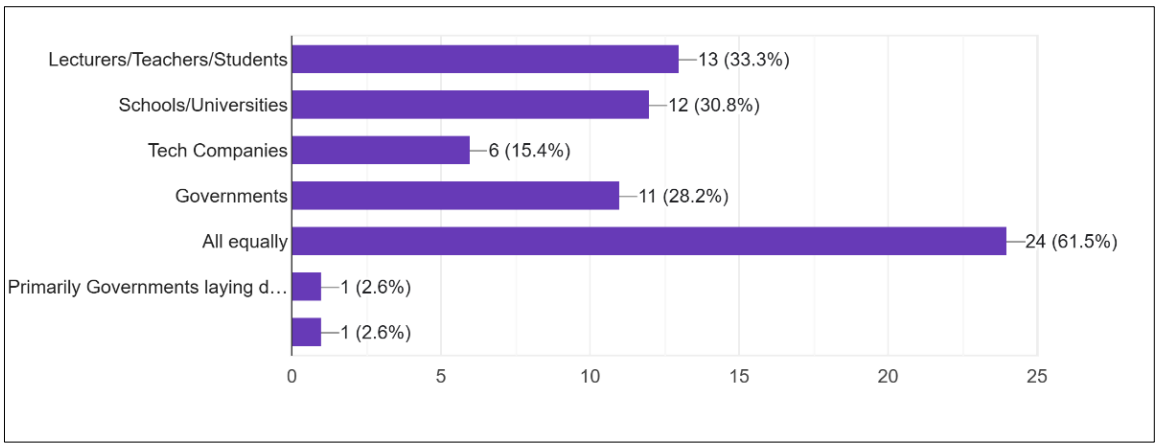


This mirrors Foltynek et al.'s (2023) argument, that educational institutions often adopt AI tools more rapidly than they establish ethical safeguards. The consistency of these responses across regions indicates that readiness gaps are global in scope, not confined to the Global South.

Expectations for Multi-Stakeholder Governance

When identifying who should be responsible for ethical AI oversight (Figure 6 on the following page), respondents most strongly endorsed a shared accountability model, with 24 of 39 (61.5%) selecting "All equally." Beyond this, responsibility was also attributed to multiple stakeholder groups: educators/students (13 of 39; 33.3%), schools/universities (12 of 39; 30.8%), and governments (11 of 39; 28.2%). Technology companies were selected less frequently (6 of 39; 15.4%), suggesting that while vendors are recognised as relevant actors, respondents primarily expect governance to be collectively owned, led by the education sector and public institutions rather than industry alone.

Figure 6: Q14. Who should be responsible for ensuring AI is used ethically in educational institutions?

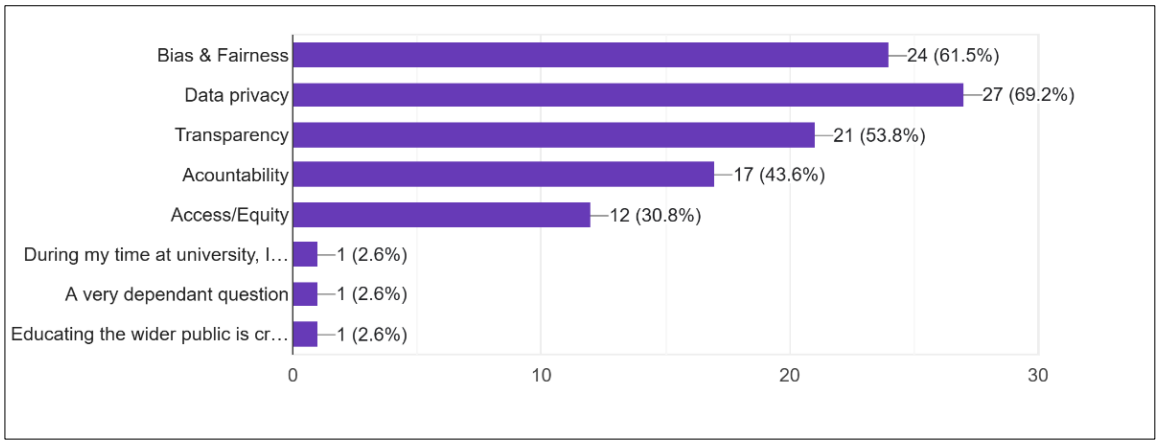


This aligns closely with Nguyen et al.'s (2023) multi-stakeholder governance model, which emphasises shared responsibility rather than centralised, top-down control. The data suggest respondents reject narrow responsibility structures and favour collaborative ethical governance.

Ethical Priorities: Privacy, Fairness, Transparency

Participants identified data privacy (27 of 39; 69.2%), bias and fairness (24 of 39; 61.5%), transparency (21 of 39; 53.8%), accountability (17 of 39; 43.6%), and access and equity (12 of 39; 30.8%) as the most important ethical priorities (see Figure 7 below).

Figure 7: Q15. Which ethical issue(s) do you think is most important to address currently?



These trends align with Karran *et al.,* (2024), who found similar global patterns in AI ethics preferences. Notably, although access and equity are frequently highlighted in Global South policy discourse, respondents prioritised algorithmic ethics over infrastructural concerns, indicating a shift towards more technically grounded ethical expectations.

Summary of Findings

Overall, the findings demonstrate a striking convergence in ethical attitudes across regions, despite clear structural differences between the Global North and Global South. Respondents expressed moderate optimism regarding AI's potential to support equitable education, paired with strong concerns about privacy, bias, and insufficient institutional readiness. The results reveal growing expectations for shared governance and highlight data privacy, algorithmic fairness, and transparency as global ethical priorities. These insights contribute novel empirical evidence showing that global ethical attitudes toward AI are increasingly aligned, while infrastructural limitations continue to shape perceptions of feasibility and implementation readiness.

6 Proposed Solutions and Recommendations

The recommendations presented below directly address the structural, ethical, and contextual gaps identified in the literature and reinforced by the primary data. They focus on strengthening institutional readiness, mitigating ethical risks, and ensuring that AI adoption in education is equitable and sustainable across diverse global contexts.

Structured Ethical AI Training for Educators and Learners

One of the clearest gaps identified in the literature is the lack of ethical literacy surrounding AI use in education, a finding strongly confirmed by the primary data, where 64.1% of respondents (25 of 39) reported insufficient ethical guidance. To address this gap, institutions should implement structured training programmes that focus on data protection, algorithmic bias, fairness, transparency, explainability, and the safe use of generative AI tools. Such programmes would directly target concerns expressed by respondents and support Foltynek et al.'s (2023) call for robust institutional guidance.

Multi-Stakeholder AI Governance Models

Primary data demonstrates that respondents favour distributed responsibility across governments, institutions, educators, students, and technology developers. This highlights a gap in current policy environments, which often rely on top-down governance. To bridge this, education systems should adopt participatory governance models such as AI ethics committees, community consultations, and co-designed policy frameworks. These recommendations align with Nguyen et al.'s (2023) model of multi-stakeholder governance and reflect user expectations for shared oversight.

Strengthen Data Governance and Bias Mitigation

The dataset indicates that 82.1% of respondents (32 of 39) hold strong concerns regarding privacy and algorithmic bias, reinforcing the literature gap regarding insufficient transparency in AI tools. Institutions should therefore adopt transparent data collection policies, independent algorithmic audits, culturally representative datasets, and clear model documentation. These measures directly respond to ethical risks highlighted by Ismail and Aloshi (2024), ensuring that AI systems operate fairly and accountably across diverse learner populations.

Address Infrastructural Barriers in Global South Contexts

Findings show that respondents from the Global South demonstrate cautious optimism toward AI's potential but remain concerned about infrastructural constraints. This reinforces earlier literature noting uneven digital readiness across regions. Priorities should

include expanding digital infrastructure, investing in teacher development, increasing access to devices, and supporting AI tools designed for low-resource environments. These recommendations are consistent with Miao *et al.'s* (2021) observations on the need for context-sensitive digital capacity.

Develop Culturally and Contextually Adaptive AI Systems

A key gap identified in the literature and validated by the emphasis on fairness and relevance in the primary data is the lack of AI systems adapted to local cultural, linguistic, and curricular contexts. AI systems should therefore be localised through language adaptation, curricular alignment, validation across regional populations, and functionality in low-connectivity environments. This supports Pedro *et al.* (2019), who argue that contextual adaptation is essential for meaningful AI deployment in Global South settings.

Prioritise Transparency and Explainability in AI Systems

The prioritisation of privacy, fairness, and transparency among respondents further highlights a gap in AI system interpretability. To build trust and support user agency, AI tools should incorporate explainable AI features, clear decision pathways, and human-in-the-loop oversight mechanisms. This recommendation reflects findings from Karran *et al.* (2024), who identify transparency as foundational for trustworthy AI adoption in education.

7 Conclusion and Future Work

This study explored global perceptions of AI in education using the Global South as a comparative context. Findings indicate a notable convergence in ethical concerns across regions, with strong emphasis on privacy, fairness, and transparency. Despite infrastructural disparities, respondents demonstrated similar governance expectations and clear recognition of ethical risks. While optimism exists particularly in the Global South, concerns about readiness and contextual fit persist.

By grounding recommendations in primary data, the study addresses identified research gaps and proposes realistic, actionable strategies for responsible AI adoption. Limitations include sample size, voluntary participation, and cross-sectional design; future work should explore longitudinal data and region-specific case studies.

AI's global trajectory suggests rising ethical awareness and a shift toward participatory governance. Ensuring equitable outcomes will require sustained commitment to capacity building, transparent governance, and ethical literacy across all regions.

Appendix A: Perceptions of AI's Role in Reducing Inequality

This equation was used to calculate the proportion of respondents within each region who expressed positive perceptions of AI's potential to reduce educational inequality, by normalising agreement responses ("4" and "5") against the total number of respondents in that region.

Global North positivity:

$$\frac{6 \text{ positive responses}}{21 \text{ total Global North respondents}} \times 100 = 28.57\% = \mathbf{28.6}\%$$

Global South positivity:

$$\frac{6 \text{ positive responses}}{15 \text{ total Global South respondents}} \times 100 = 40.00\% = \mathbf{40.0}\%$$

Calculate the difference:

$$40.0\% - 28.6\% = \mathbf{11.4 \text{ percentage points}}$$

The remaining positive response (1 of 13 positive responses overall) came from a respondent who selected "Prefer not to say" for region and is therefore excluded from this regional comparison.

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